Shah had a less convincing answer as to why tickets were given to MLAs who were charged with inciting the riots; he tamely claimed they had been 'defamed'. I also asked him about his controversial remark ahead of polling that UP's voters should exact 'revenge'. 'I was referring to the ballot box, not the gun. You media people are just trying to create trouble,' he insisted.

But the subtext of Shah's statement was apparent. It was obvious that post-Muzaffarnagar, a certain Hindu consolidation had taken place on the ground and Shah could reap its political advantage. In the six months after the riots, there were several minor communal flare-ups across western UP—stone throwing, local skirmishes, fights over loudspeakers—and with every instance, the religious divide widened. A senior UP police officer later told me that a pattern had been established as early as May 2012, soon after Akhilesh Yadav took over. 'Every week, we would get reports of communal tension from some district headquarters. It started in western UP, but spread to central and eastern UP,' he told me.

In October 2013, I travelled to Bareilly, a town that had seen a month-long bandh the previous year after riots broke out during Ramzan. A year had elapsed, but the divide on the ground was visible. In the Muslim mohallas, the Shah–Modi combine was seen as an 'evil' duo. '*Woh toh dange karvayenge, UP ko Gujarat banayenge!*' (They will incite riots, make UP into Gujarat), said a Muslim schoolteacher. Interestingly, in the Hindu bastis, too, there was a feeling that UP would become Gujarat if Modi became prime minister. '*Dekho, sir, Gujarat ne kitni tarakki ki hai, hum peechhe reh gaye!*' (See how Gujarat has progressed, we are left behind), a young graduate told me. It seemed that Modi was seen as a threat by the Muslims, but represented hope and opportunity to the Hindus.

The Muzaffarnagar riots drew the politically influential Jats into the BJP fold. But it wasn't just the Jats or upper castes alone—the Sangh Parivar made a deliberate attempt to woo Dalits as well, in an effort to cement an umbrella 'Hindu' identity. Mayawati was strangely muted in the aftermath of Muzaffarnagar, and the BJP sensed an opportunity. The RSS consciously wooed non-Jatav Dalit groups like the Pasis, even distributing pamphlets claiming that their ancestors were *raksha*k*s* (protectors) of the Hindu faith.